



ENGL 1405 World Literature Unit 4

Essentials for Writing Critical Analysis of Poetry

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Although it is a widespread practice to use the words “poetry” and “poem” interchangeably, there is a difference between the two. **Poetry** is the literary genre known for using language to evoke meaning through rhythm and imagery. A **poem** is a single piece of literature within the poetry genre. When you have more than one poem that has been compiled by scholars or the author, it is called a **collection** of poems. When you seek to critically analyze poetry, you are aiming to identify the meaning of a single or collection of poems. Poetry analysis aims to look at all the different parts of a poem to see how they work together. Critical analysis of poetry can be applied in different ways depending on different aspects of the poem; however, there are some key aspects of a poem that are important in every critical analysis.

Theme

Poetry often features figurative language that the poet uses to convey their message. The central idea and the subject matter can help you understand the theme of the poem you are analyzing. There are two types of themes: explicit and implicit. **Explicit themes** are clearly stated and leave no room for ambiguity. Implicit themes are the opposite.

Implicit themes are themes not directly stated by the author but implied and assumed by the reader.

Language

The language a poet uses in their poem is important to how we read and analyze the poem. Looking at word choice, imagery, metaphors, etc., we can assume the tone of the poem. The way the words are arranged also directly impacts how we read the poem. Literal language is when the poet uses words that are direct and clear. **Literal language** is clear and direct and free from any figurative language, symbolism, or imagery. **Figurative language** is language that aims to create a link or compare abstract ideas and concrete objects by using everyday words and/or phrases.

Figurative language is a key competent to creating imagery. Figurative language is used by authors to help convey their message clearly in terms the audience can relate to.

There are different types of figurative language, **the common types of figurative language (aka figures of speech)** used in poetry are:

Allusion: When a text references another outside text, event, person or place. It may be explicit or implicit. Example: “He is my Romeo” is an allusion that references



Shakespeare's famous play *Romero and Juliet*. "You've opened Pandora's box" is a reference to Greek mythology. Pandora (the first woman on earth) was gifted a box from the gods. This allusion means that something bad, or misfortunate may happen, but there is still hope.

Simile: A figure of speech that compares two unrelated concepts using a connecting word—such as "like" or "as." Example: "She was slow as a sloth," or "I ran like a cheetah."

Metaphor: Similar to a simile, but without any connecting words. It simply implies that two unrelated things are the same. Example: "She was a sloth," or "I am a cheetah."

Personification: Language that projects human qualities onto something nonhuman—such as an object, animal or abstract idea. Example: "The wind barked," and "The light danced."

Hyperbole: Language is extravagant and intentionally exaggerated. Example: "I died of laughter," or "I'm so happy, I could die!"

Idiom: A non-literal phrase that is common among most people that speak the same language. An English example of an idiom would be, "It's raining cats and dogs," which means that it is heavily raining.

Onomatopoeia: words that sound like the thing they are attempting to describe.

Common example would be a cellphone "beeping" or bees "buzzing." Onomatopoeia is also used to describe sound effects such as "zip" or "boom."

Sound, Rhyme, and Rhythm

Much like music, poetry has a sound too. The way the words are arranged and how you read them matter to the sound and rhythm of a poem (**prosody**). You can hear it the most when you read a poem out aloud. Sound focuses on how the individual words work together and the poem's overall experience. Repetition of sounds encourages the reader to feel a certain way.

Rhyme occurs in poetry when the sounds of syllables match up, typically at the end of a line. Rhyme helps with the flow of poetry; it also helps the reader anticipate what comes next. Rhyme schemes are often found by looking at the last word in each line and giving each word that rhymes its own letter. It is important to note that rhyme schemes can change from line to line, stanza to stanza, or can continue throughout a poem. Example: (lines from Shakespeare's Sonnet 14)

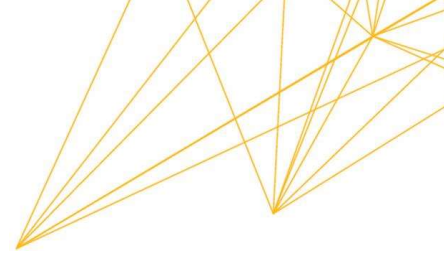
Not from the stars do I my judgement pluck, (A)

And yet methinks I have astronomy— (B)

But not to tell of good or evil luck, (A)

Of plagues, of dearths, or seasons' quality; (B)

Rhythm in poetry can be irregular or regular. Rhythm is created by a pattern of stressed (/) or unstressed (x) syllables in a line or verse, which is known as a **meter**. Again,



learning the poems' rhythm helps if the poem is read aloud. Rhythm also sets the pace of the poem for the audience.

Common types of meters are:

Iambic: a sequence of one unstressed syllable immediately followed by a stressed syllable. Example: the word “a-PPEAR” is an iamb (x /) and the Shakespeare sonnet above is in iambic pentameter. Look at the first line: “Not FROM the STARS do I my JUDGEment PLUCK,”

Trochaic: the exact opposite of an iamb. It is one stressed syllable followed by an unstressed syllable. Example: “gar-DEN” (/ x)

Spondaic: a pattern where two stressed syllables appear back-to-back; usually used to create an energetic and insistent tone. Example: “DOWNTOWN” (/ /)

Anapestic: is a pattern of two unstressed syllables followed by a stressed syllable. Example: “in-ter-RUPT” (x x /)

Dactylic: is the opposite of anapestic, one strong syllable followed by two weak syllables. Example: “PO-et-ry” (/ x x)

Structure

The structure of a poem lies in its framework. The structure determines how the poem should be read. The poet uses different structural devices to create their story, a few popular structural devices are:

Lines: A line in a poem is a single row of words. A line does not have to be a complete sentence and there can be an unlimited number of lines in a poem. Additionally, not all lines need to be the same length.

Stanza: A group of lines is called a stanza. A stanza aims to group the ideas of the poem together. Much like lines, there are no rules to how many stanzas can be in a poem. Additionally, a stanza can consist of any number of lines. Furthermore, stanzas within a single poem can be all the same length or many different lengths. Think of stanzas like a paragraph in prose.

Couplet: A couplet is a pair of lines in a poem that go together. The lines are similar in length and rhythm. When a couplet does rhyme, it is known as a **rhyming couplet**. When analyzing poetry, readers must pay attention to the different ways that poets decide to end a line of a verse. There are different techniques and ways to recognize them.

End-stop: an end-stop is a pause at the end of a line of poetry. End-stops are marked by either a full stop (period), semicolon, comma, or other types of punctuation marks that draw attention to the end of a complete thought or phrase.

Enjambment: This is the opposite of an end-stop. Enjambment is recognized by the lack of punctuation, indicating that the phrase extends past the end of the line in a poem. Without any punctuation, the reader must continue reading though the break in a line to reach the conclusion of the speaker's thoughts.



Caesura: A feature used by poets to signal to the reader that there is an audible pause in the middle of a meter. A caesura can be recognized by punctuation or two vertical lines “||”, which is called a scansion. Caesurae can be labeled by where they are in the line:

- Initial Caesura: A pause at the beginning of a line.
- Medial Caesura: A pause in the middle of a line (and most common).
- Terminal Caesura: A pause near the end of a line.

Context

Context in poetry, much like in traditional prose, is the who, what, when, and why of the poem that helps explain the poet’s purpose. Context is important for understanding what the poet is trying to convey to the audience and helps strengthen the audience’s comprehension of the poem to understand it. The context can be historical, physical, situational, or cultural.

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